when Rahul was bowled by a beauty from Wasim. Azhar soon followed and when Sourav got out we were down to 82–5 and badly needed a partnership.

When Nayan Mongia came out to join me in the middle I asked him to be patient and just play himself in. With the cream of our batting back in the dressing room, I realized it was time for me to take charge. I was fully focused on the job at hand and had gone into a zone where I was praying before each ball was bowled. Even when Nayan was on strike I was rehearsing in my mind how I'd have played the balls bowled to him. In effect, I was trying to bat at both ends. As I concentrated really hard, everything else around me seemed a blur and all I knew was that I had to bat through to the end of the game.

And then the pain struck. It was forty-five minutes before tea when I felt a scorching pain in my back. By now Nayan and I had put together a good partnership and the game was starting to tilt ever so slightly towards India. But Pakistan had yet to take the new ball and I knew we still had a fair amount of work to do. Wasim and Waqar would give their best in one final burst. The hot and humid conditions in Chennai were harsh and I was starting to suffer from cramp. Playing each ball was turning out to be an ordeal and the pain in my back was becoming unbearable. The tea break came as a blessed relief. I remember lying flat on a towel in the dressing room with cold towels spread all over me to bring down my body temperature. My whole body was cramping up and I knew it was going to be really difficult to bat for two more hours.

After tea I had no choice but to attack the bowling, because I knew my back was about to give up. I informed Nayan of the change in strategy and hit a few boundaries in the next few overs. Soon the target was down to manageable proportions and we just needed to play out the second new ball. We had put on 136 runs for the sixth wicket and Pakistan were gradually losing their grip on the match. In fact, we were cruising along when Nayan got out to a bad shot. He tried a slog to a Wasim delivery and top-edged the ball in the process. There was no need to play that shot and it had once again given Pakistan a ray of hope. It was a sad end to a very good innings from Nayan.

Sunil Joshi, who came in next, settled well and even hit a six off Saqlain during his forty-minute stay at the wicket. We made 36 in the six overs after Nayan got out and the target was now just 17 runs away. In the meantime my back had all but given up on me and I was finding it